

Develop and Demonstrate Loyalty: Introduction, Featuring Greg Hiebert

Greg Hiebert, Leadership Coach & Managing Partner

By far the greatest influence and source of purpose in Pat Summitt's life was family. As much as she loved basketball, competition, and, of course, winning, family always came first. So it is not surprising that she created and nurtured the family model within Tennessee basketball. Her assistant coaches stayed with her for decades, through triumphs and travails, through every up and every down, because she treated them as so much more than just paid employees. To Pat Summitt, they were family, and her loyalty to family was absolute ... a non-negotiable.

In fact, today, years after the untimely passing of Coach Summitt, hundreds of former players, assistant coaches, and colleagues consider themselves all part of Coach Pat Summitt's family.

Coach Summitt said, "To build a sound organization, you must surround yourself with people who share the same basic values. People who are constant and who will be true to your organization. In pressure situations, you don't wonder how the person next to you will react. You know."

Isn't it better to work with someone you have a regard for ... in a relationship with ... someone you have shared good and bad with ... and have developed some trust in and loyalty to?

The single most common reason organizations self-destruct is disloyalty, especially when they are made up of young people who have a tendency to talk behind each other's back. When Coach Summitt talked about loyalty, it is powerfully revealing to notice that the conversation always started with her focus of being loyal, not on receiving loyalty, as well as expressing her appreciation for those who were deeply loyal to her.

Coach Summitt was asked how she kept her core staff intact for so long. She replied, "How do you keep your family? I'll tell you. You take care of your family, and you protect your family."

And the next obvious question is: How do you do that? Paying people well is a start, but you must find a way to show that you appreciate them, even with a simple gesture like buying them lunch. The joy that comes from giving without worrying about what you'll receive in return is the unsolicited bonus that comes when you demonstrate genuine loyalty, for only when you give it away will it come back to you.